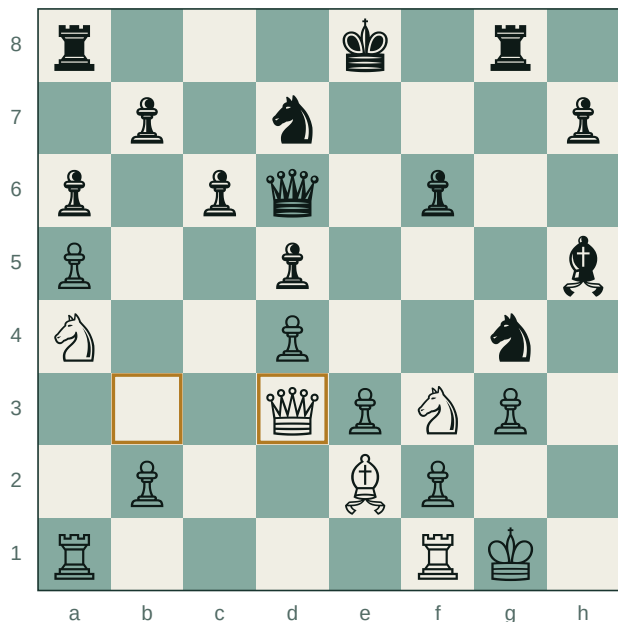


Capture the defender: Black, move 18

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 18.Qd3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

18...Nxf2 19. Rxf2 Qxg3+ 20. Kf1 Bxf3

18...Nxf2 The knight captures the pawn on f2. The changed line means the bishop on h5 attacks the knight on f3.
Recorded reply: **19.Rxf2**.

19...Qxg3+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. From g3 it attacks king on g1, rook on f2 and knight on f3.
Recorded reply: **20.Kf1**.

20...Bxf3 The bishop captures the knight on f3.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 31 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +2. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +2:** the balance goes from +0 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on g1. Look for a defender that can be displaced or overloaded.